

South Sudan Nexus Digest

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Connecting humanitarian, development and peace efforts

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The waters will come in South Sudan. Flood resilience must come first.

Over one million people are affected by flooding in South Sudan each year. But following years of a response largely centered on humanitarian assistance, how are the Government, UN and partners adapting in 2026 in the wake of unprecedented funding cuts, to sustain progress and prevent hard-won gains from being reversed?



Women canoeing on floodwater that has submerged entire forests in Bentiu, Unity State. Photo Credit: IOM

Five years ago, South Sudan experienced the most severe flooding in 60 years, affecting 33 out of 78 counties. Over 800,000 people were newly displaced while homes, farmlands and infrastructure were submerged under water. [Economic damages](#) for that year alone were estimated at US\$671 million.

Since then, severe flooding has become a grim fact of life for many communities, driven by

intense seasonal rainfall (April to November), rising water levels in Lake Victoria with a consequent increase in Nile inflows, and the erratic impacts of climate change.

In 2026, the UN and its partners are preparing for the worst. Rainfall already came “much earlier than usual,” according to the South Sudan Meteorological Services, indicating high probability of wetter conditions. The World

Meteorological Organization (WMO) signaled an [80 per cent likelihood](#) of an El Niño event, associated with increased rainfall in parts of the Horn of Africa and other regions, during June-August 2026.

For those living in conflict-affected areas, this adds another layer of vulnerability.

“The floods took everything from us: our homes, our farms, even our animals. We are safe behind the dykes, but we dream of the day when we can live on our own land again and rebuild our lives,” said one resident in the Bentiu IDP Camp.

The camp is located in Unity - one of the worst affected South Sudanese states by flooding. Its residents are protected from floodwater by dykes, reinforced with sandbags each year by the International Organization for Migration (IOM) and partners, and in coordination with state authorities.

A humanitarian origin, a predictable crisis?

The flooding response in South Sudan has for over a decade operated through an emergency clockwork: prepare, assess, respond. Last year, humanitarian partners provided shelters, sanitation items, cash-for-work opportunities, water drainage and dyke support, among other assistance in response to new [flood-driven displacements](#) in 18 counties.

The National Flooding Taskforce, set up in 2023, is co-chaired by the Relief and Rehabilitation Commission (RRC) and

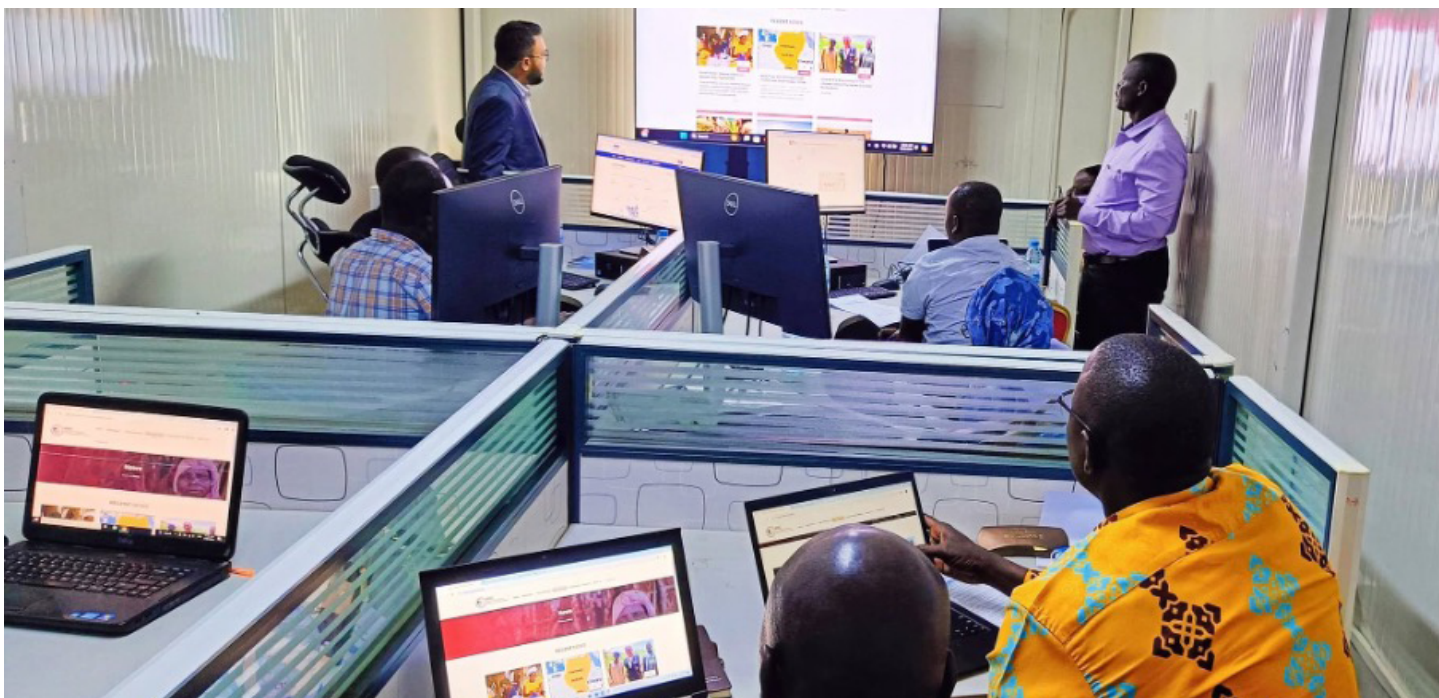
United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) with participation extending to both humanitarian and development partners. Its humanitarian origin was a reaction to the devastating toll of excessive flooding at the time, where life-saving actions took precedence over all else.

But today, flooding carries layers of predictability. Hot spots have already been mapped out by partners: Jonglei, Northern Bahr el Ghazal, Unity and Upper Nile. Risk assessments are regularly informed by models leveraging digital technology and artificial intelligence. Regular conflict-sensitivity analysis by the United Nations Mission in South Sudan (UNMISS) and peace partners has been critical to mitigate risks of communal tensions due to new displacements and competition over scarce resources.

Anchoring resilience in a volatile climate

As the UN and its partners continue to grapple with severe resource constraints in 2026, the shift from a response largely centered on humanitarian assistance to longer-term solutions has become increasingly urgent.

One of the recommendations emerging from the 2025 flood after-action review, which brought together government authorities, aid workers and other stakeholders, calls for greater investment in mitigation measures and structural interventions to reduce the recurring impact of floods. A key lesson is that floods should not be viewed solely as a humanitarian challenge. With the right investments, seasonal water flows can also create opportunities for resilience, livelihoods and economic growth. This includes improved water management, flood-resilient agriculture and activities such as rice cultivation, which can help communities benefit from, rather than simply endure, recurring floods.



The National Coordination and Operations Center (NCOC) in Juba serves as a coordination mechanism for emergency preparedness, response and recovery programming led by the Government of South Sudan. Photo Credit: UNDP

Examples of this shift are already emerging. In Warrap, rice cultivation was introduced to flood-prone areas by the World Food Programme (WFP) and partners, turning unusable floodplains into productive fields. In Northern Bahr el Ghazal, UNHCR, the United Nations Refugee Agency, and partners are providing nearly 600 climate-resilient shelters and latrines in three counties this year.

More systematic approaches are also taking shape. In Unity, flooding is increasingly treated not only as an emergency but also as a planning parameter. Integrated investments combining safe land, water access, roads and agricultural support are enabling communities to settle in less flood-prone areas and restart productive activities.

At the national level, the [National Coordination and Operations Center \(NCOC\)](#) was launched in April 2024, supported by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), and serves as a central hub for information dissemination, early warnings, and response coordination under the leadership of the Government of South Sudan. The Government has also

initiated a [climate resilience project](#) aimed at establishing the country's first ever multi-hazard early warning system.

Policy and coordination frameworks are advancing. The Validation Workshop of the Revised National Disaster Risk Management Policy in May 2026, held by the Government in collaboration with IGAD and the UN (FAO, UNDP, UNDRR, WFP) marked an important step in strengthening disaster risk governance. During the same month, UNDP also launched a mapping exercise of development initiatives to strengthen coordination and identify opportunities for greater investment in resilience.

Together, these efforts point towards a more development-oriented approach to flood management: one that prioritizes resilience, climate-informed planning and long-term solutions alongside emergency response. As resources continue to dwindle and climate shocks intensify, getting ahead of the waters is no longer simply an option - it is a necessity.

FEATURE

South Sudan's food paradox

Abundant in arable land that surpasses that of many of its neighbors, South Sudan has the potential to become a regional breadbasket. But persistent insecurity, climate shocks, limited market access, and other constraints continue to undermine agricultural production. The country spends over USD 800 million annually on food imports while millions of South Sudanese rely on emergency food aid.

Food insecurity in South Sudan has gradually climbed over the years. In ten years, the number of people facing crisis or emergency levels of food insecurity during the lean season jumped from [4.8 million people](#) in 2016 to [7.8 million](#) in 2026 - more than half of South Sudan's population. Of these, around 73,000 people are facing "catastrophic" hunger (IPC 5), experiencing extreme food consumption gaps associated with starvation, heightened risk of death, and the collapse of livelihoods.

In parts of states such as Jonglei, Upper Nile, Lakes and Central Equatoria, [repeated shocks](#) have significantly undermined households' access to food and nutrition services. While recent displacements have had a relatively ["marginal impact"](#) on overall crop production,

it has exacerbated food insecurity in affected communities. In areas with renewed fighting and other emergencies, food assistance remains a lifeline for communities in need.

However, outside the areas most affected by conflict and food insecurity, there are significant economic opportunities for the country to leverage its 33 million acres of prime arable land. South Sudan possesses more arable land than neighboring Kenya or Uganda. Yet, [less than five per cent](#) of this land is currently utilized, despite more than 80 per cent of the population engaging in rural subsistence farming. Low levels of productivity, limited infrastructure and market constraints continue to contribute to dependence on food imports and humanitarian assistance.



Communities in Malakal County, Upper Nile State, are strengthening their resilience to climate change through climate-smart agriculture and good agricultural practices supported by the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO). Before the sun rises, 43-year-old farmer Adwok Jud is already in his field, checking for weeds, tilling the soil with his hoe, and watering neat rows of onions, tomatoes, kudra, and sweet potatoes. Photo Credit: FAO

The race to agricultural resilience

In 2025, amidst unprecedented funding cuts, the UN and humanitarian leadership in South Sudan set shared goals of contributing to a net increase of 30,000 metric tons of food production, with 10,000 hectares of land brought under climate-resilient agricultural practices, by mid-2026.

This builds on growing national efforts to strengthen agricultural production and food systems. For example, in 2024, the Government of South Sudan launched the [Food and Agriculture Delivery Compact](#), outlining political, financial, and partner commitments to “transform agriculture and livestock into a thriving sector,” with a focus on sorghum, rice, sesame, and fisheries. That same year, the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) and the Ministry of Agriculture and Food Security launched two initiatives aimed at empowering rural enterprises and strengthening food systems: the six-year [Rural Enterprises for Agricultural Development \(READ\)](#) programme and the Empowering Women and Youth to Drive Sustainable Agriculture (EWYSA) project.

Early results have been encouraging. South Sudan’s 2025 net cereal production, estimated at [1.2 million tonnes](#), represents an eight per cent increase compared to the previous year. The area of harvested cereal land also expanded due to increased farming activities, including among returnees from Sudan and urban households seeking a secondary source of income.

However, as external funding continues to decline, the need for accelerated risk-informed investments that reduce reliance on food imports and strengthen the entire agrifood system has become increasingly urgent. Such investments must extend beyond food production to encompass storage, processing, transport, market access and value addition.



The Koyle Farmers Group in Rejaf West, Central Equatoria, supported by the EWYSA project to boost the livelihoods of small-scale vegetable farmers, pose with their farm produce. Photo Credit: UNDP

This call was echoed at the [2026 National Agriculture Conference](#), hosted in May in Juba, under the theme “Investing in Agri-food Systems for Better Life in South Sudan”. The conference brought together government leaders, development partners, the private sector and community representatives. Participants emphasized the importance of expanding private sector-led investment across crop, livestock and fisheries value chains, supported by greater investments in mechanization, irrigation, infrastructure, market development and value addition. The conference also adopted a formal Communiqué recommending, among other measures, that the national government allocate at least 10 per cent of the national budget to agriculture in line with regional commitments.

Shocks will continue to affect South Sudan, including floods that devastate farmlands and volatile prices that place food beyond the reach of many households. Yet the country’s long-term food security and economic resilience will depend on its ability to mobilize the investments needed to unlock its considerable agricultural potential.

The women who opened a restaurant in South Sudan's largest camp



Theresa Nyagoang Lei, former Chair of the Women Forum in Unity's Bentiu IDP Camp. Photo Credit: RCO

Theresa Nyagoang Lei served as the Chair of the Women Forum last year in South Sudan's largest displacement camp, the Bentiu IDP Camp, where 109,000 people reside. The group, comprising 57 women, meets biweekly to discuss problems in the camp, propose solutions and plan community activities, such as annual events in commemoration of the 16 Days of Activism against Gender-Based Violence.

During her tenure, Theresa represented the women's group in the State Task Force on Durable Solutions which brought together government authorities, UN agencies and non-governmental organizations (NGOs). There,



Over 109,000 people live in Bentiu IDP Camp - South Sudan's largest displacement site. Photo Credit: RCO

“The opening of this restaurant has been my proudest moment. We get around 50 customers per day and many more during the weekends,” said Theresa, who continues to work there to this day, supervising other cooks.

she voiced not only the collective concerns of women in the camp but also their perspectives and grassroots ideas for improving living conditions and advancing durable solutions.

In 2024, the group pitched the idea of opening a restaurant in the camp to sell affordable home-cooked meals to its residents. By October 2025,

this idea became a reality, run and managed by the Women Forum, with the support of the International Organization for Migration (IOM), which constructed the facility, providing cooking materials, kitchen sets and initial ingredients to kick off its opening.

The restaurant is open daily from 8 am to 7 pm with a changing menu that commonly features rice, beans, fish and other local dishes. The women use the earnings to buy ingredients, helping to sustain the business.

For Theresa, who has lived in the camp since 2014, the restaurant offers more than just a reliable source of affordable food, particularly during the rainy season when roads become flooded and access to markets is more difficult. In her words, it provides a “beacon of hope for the community.”



Various shots of the restaurant in the camp and members of the Women Forum. Photo Credit: RCO

Theresa first fled to the Bentiu IDP Camp with her five children. Today, she shares her tented home with three of them, its walls lined with brightly patterned fabric, topped by a straw roof. Like many communities across South Sudan, Theresa and other residents of the Bentiu IDP camp are feeling the effects of declining humanitarian funding, even as needs remain high.

When asked about conditions in the camp, she shared: “A lot has changed and not for the better. We are receiving less assistance. Water and sanitation services have severely declined compared to two years ago and more people are resorting to open defecation because of poor conditions in the latrines.”

Given the deteriorating sanitation conditions, Theresa is particularly concerned about the ongoing cholera outbreak. Earlier this

May, suspected cholera cases in Unity State surpassed the alert threshold with most cases reported in the IDP camp. According to the [World Health Organization \(WHO\)](#), the cholera outbreak, which was formally declared in October 2024, has reached 103,956 cases and 1,673 deaths across South Sudan, as of 22 May.

Despite these challenges, Theresa remains hopeful: “When life gets difficult, one should not stop working. My thoughts are now on how to expand the restaurant given that I have passed the baton as Chairwoman of the Women Forum.”



Various shots of the restaurant in the camp and members of the Women Forum. Photo Credit: RCO

Upper Nile: Where coordination meets community resilience



Communities led a cleaning campaign in March 2026, including the removal of metal scraps, after returning to Hai Matar and Hai Luakat following years of displacement. Photo Credit: ABC

The Upper Nile state, particularly Malakal, has been one of the most affected areas in South Sudan by conflict, displacement and recurrent climatic shocks. At the same time, durable solutions efforts are increasingly supporting voluntary return, local integration and reintegration. Today, Upper Nile hosts over 225,000 internally displaced persons (IDPs) and more than 736,000 returnees, the highest number among all states.

Based in Malakal, **Dmytro Charskykh, Area-Based Coordinator for Upper Nile**, leads durable solutions coordination efforts with the Government and partners. In a short interview, he shares his experiences, highlighting achievements and challenges, but also opportunities, since the launch of the state-level roadmap on durable solutions in 2024.

Could you tell us more about the Upper Nile Durable Solutions Roadmap and what is its significance?

Charskykh: The Roadmap, which runs from 2024 to 2026, was designed to move the response beyond emergency assistance towards longer-term recovery and resilience for IDPs, returnees and host communities. It brings together government, humanitarian, development, and peace actors around shared strategic priorities, including access to basic services, livelihoods, social cohesion, and strengthening local systems. Importantly, displacement-affected communities are also active partners in this process, shaping and guiding their solutions. Since its launch in 2024, we have seen stronger government leadership and coordination among partners, and more consistent engagement

with local authorities and communities. We have also seen stronger linkages between humanitarian, peacebuilding, recovery and development programming.

What has been concretely achieved since the launch of the roadmap in 2024?

Charskykh: Through [collective efforts](#) under the Government, more than 3,400 formerly displaced people have returned or reintegrated across Upper Nile since 2024, including those who used to live in the former “Protection of Civilians” site in Malakal. Over 137,000 people were supported on Housing, Land and Property rights. Partners have rehabilitated water points, schools, and health facilities, expanded livelihood opportunities and community-based conflict resolution efforts. However, durable solutions are not only about infrastructure and services - they are fundamentally about dignity, inclusion and peace.

In 2026, the Government and the UN have committed to extend the Roadmap by an additional two years, through 2028. The next phase will expand coverage to all counties in Upper Nile and incorporate solutions strategies for refugees in Maban and Renk.

In your view, what have been the key challenges in implementing durable solutions in the Upper Nile? And what have been key areas of opportunities?

Charskykh: The key challenges remain insecurity, which affects counties like Nasir, Ulang, Longochuk and Baltet, recurrent flooding, displacement cycles, weak infrastructure and limited funding. Seasonal flooding continues to disrupt access in parts of the state, affecting livelihoods and service delivery. Limited economic opportunities and pressure on basic services make sustainable return more difficult. Despite these challenges, communities have consistently shown strong willingness to recover and rebuild when conditions allow.



Representatives of communities, the Government, United Nations and NGOs gathered for a workshop on the transition of the Malakal “Protection of Civilians” site held in March 2026. Dmytro Charskykh (top), Area-Based Coordinator in Upper Nile, highlighted the state-level durable solutions roadmap in the workshop. Photo credit: ABC

In Upper Nile, integrated interventions combining livelihoods support, rehabilitation of community infrastructure, and support to local governance structures have contributed to greater stability in displacement-affected areas, specifically in Malakal, Fashoda and Manyo counties, which also host significant numbers of refugees and returnees from Sudan. Community-led approaches have also helped strengthen trust between displaced and host communities, reducing tensions and supporting peaceful coexistence in areas where resources remain under pressure.

The UN and its partners have faced unprecedented funding cuts since last year. Has that affected durable solutions efforts in the Upper Nile, and if so, in what ways?

Charskykh: Yes, the funding cuts are having a significant impact. Durable solutions require sustained and predictable investments, but many partners are being forced to scale back activities and focus primarily on life-saving interventions. In Upper Nile, this has affected field presence, coordination capacity, assessments, and the continuity of recovery and resilience programs. Some planned activities related to livelihoods, infrastructure rehabilitation, and community engagement have been delayed or reduced which risks slowing progress towards greater self-reliance and resilience. At the same time, the funding environment has pushed partners to strengthen prioritization, improve coordination, and work more closely with local actors to maximize impact with limited resources. It has also reinforced the importance of targeting investments where they can deliver the greatest long-term benefits for communities.

Looking ahead, what would you say are the priorities for the next two years and what is the case for investment?

Charskykh: As the current roadmap concludes, the priority should be to capitalize on existing progress and transition toward a more sustainable, locally owned approach. The next phase should prioritize strengthening local institutions, expanding access to services, supporting livelihoods and climate resilience, and deepening collaboration between humanitarian, development, and peace actors.

There is also a need for more flexible and multi-year funding that allows partners to move beyond life-saving activities, support long-term recovery and reduce aid dependency. Ultimately, investing in durable solutions is an investment in social cohesion, local stability and the resilience of communities. The experience in Upper Nile has shown that even modest but sustained investments can deliver tangible results when they are community-driven, well-coordinated and aligned with local priorities.

On a more personal note: what does a typical day as an Area-Based Coordinator look like, and what motivates you about this role?

Charskykh: In my dual role as Area-Based Coordinator and UNHCR Head of Office in Malakal, my work involves a daily balance between coordination, field engagement and operational delivery. I work closely with humanitarian, development, peacebuilding partners, local authorities and community representatives to ensure that interventions are aligned with local priorities and that operational challenges are addressed collectively. In a context like Upper Nile, flexibility and continuous engagement with communities and authorities are essential. What motivates me most is seeing communities take active steps toward recovery despite very difficult conditions. It is rewarding to support processes that help people move toward greater stability, dignity and self-reliance.

Charskykh with community members during the cleaning campaign for Hai Matar and Hai Luakat. Photo Credit: ABC





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